

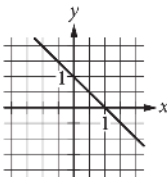
Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Algebra	Linear equations in two variables	Hard

Question
 $ax + by = b$

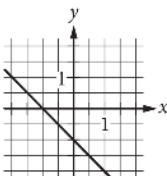
In the equation above, a and b are constants and $0 < a < b$. Which of the following could represent the graph of the equation in the xy-plane?

Answer

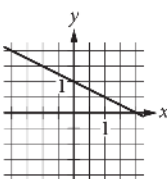
A.



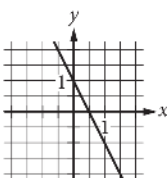
B.



C.



D.



Rationale

Choice C is correct. The given equation $ax + by = b$ can be rewritten in slope-intercept form, $y = mx + k$, where m represents the slope of the line represented by the equation, and k represents the y -coordinate of the y -intercept of the line. Subtracting ax from both sides of the equation yields $by = -ax + b$, and dividing both sides of this equation by b yields $y = -\frac{a}{b}x + \frac{b}{b}$, or $y = -\frac{a}{b}x + 1$. With the equation now in slope-intercept form, it shows that $k = 1$, which means the y -coordinate of the y -intercept is 1. It's given that a and b are both greater than 0 (positive) and that $a < b$. Since $m = -\frac{a}{b}$, the slope of the line must be a value between -1 and 0. Choice C is the only graph of a line that has a y -value of the y -intercept that is 1 and a slope that is between -1 and 0.

Choices A, B, and D are incorrect because the slopes of the lines in these graphs aren't between -1 and 0.